



Tablet.” Traditionally attributed to the legendary figure of Hermes Trismegistus, it is now thought to be of Arabic origin and to date from the 500s to 700s. An inspiration for alchemists, its cryptic text was thought to contain alchemical secrets and Hermetic ideas of achieving balance between each human and the cosmos. It influenced such eminent Renaissance figures as John Dee, Isaac Newton, and the 16th-century doctor and alchemist Paracelsus, whose innovative contributions to medicine were

based on such ideas of balance. Hermeticism’s core principle—the existence of a universal force uniting the microcosm with the macrocosm—is often expressed with the phrase “As above, so below,” itself a summary of the Tablet’s words: “That which is Below corresponds to that which is Above, and that which is Above corresponds to that which is Below, to accomplish the miracles of the One Thing.” For alchemists, the “One Thing” was a reference to their ultimate goal: the Philosopher’s Stone.

▲ **Cryptic carving**
Alchemist Heinrich Khunrath’s *Amphitheatrum sapientiae aeternae* (1609) includes this fanciful imagining of the green stone tablet on which Hermes Trismegistus is reputed to have carved his Emerald Tablet text.

“... by fire, Of sooty coal th’ empiric alchymist,
Can turn, or holds it possible to turn,
Metals of drossiest ore to perfect gold ...”